

The Jostedalsbreen Icefield

The largest glacier in mainland Europe, a remnant of a vast ice sheet that covered the whole of Norway until about 10,000 years ago



The Jostedal Icefield (*breen* is Norwegian for “glacier”) lies in southwestern Norway and has an area of about 185 square miles (480 square km), with its highest point at 6,421 ft (1,957 m) above sea level. In places, its ice is more than 1,300 ft (400 m) thick. The icefield survives primarily because of high regional snowfall rather than particularly cold temperatures.

Locked-up water

The top, or central, part of the icefield is a slightly undulating and largely featureless expanse of white ice and the source of numerous outlet glaciers. The total mass of ice corresponds to approximately 300 billion bathtubs of water, or all of Norway’s water use for 100 years. However, this mass is diminishing, as reflected by a high rate of melting at the snouts of Jostedalsbreen’s outlet glaciers. Some of these, such as Nigardsbreen, contain spectacular blue ice caves.

▽ GLACIER TOUR

A line of climbers, equipped with poles and crampons, make their way up Briksdalsbreen, one of the most accessible of Jostedalsbreen’s outlet glaciers.



△ **AZURE GROTTO**
Ice of such a deep blue color as seen in this cave is very dense and strong, containing fewer air bubbles than white ice.

JOSTEDALSBREEN'S OUTLET GLACIERS

The Jostedalsbreen Icefield has a long, thin shape, with a maximum length of some 40 miles (65 km). About 50 outlet glaciers flow out of the icefield and down to the valleys below. Four of the largest are marked below.

